

Voice-Leading Rule Review and Correction Guide

Source analyzed:

Prelude and Fugue for Recorders in G - Full score - 01 Fugue.musicxml

Summary from current report:

- Total flags: 205
- Leading tone unresolved: 33
- Voice crossing: 20
- Parallel unisons: 107
- Parallel octaves: 13
- Parallel P5ths: 17
- Large leap: 11
- Melodic tritone: 2
- Direct 5ths: 2

Important context:

Many flags mention Viola. If you intend to work with the reduced 4-recorder version only, re-run analysis after removing Viola so counts and examples match the current score exactly.

1) Leading Tone Unresolved (33)

Why this rule is flagged:

- In tonal counterpoint, the leading tone (scale degree 7) has strong tendency to resolve up by semitone to tonic.
- In G major, that means F# is expected to move to G in accented or cadential contexts.
- The analyzer flags cases where F# holds, descends, or leaps elsewhere instead of resolving to G.

Representative report examples:

- m.4 beat 1.00 (Alto): F# -> E
- m.7 beat 2.50 (Soprano): F# -> A
- m.21 beat 4.00 (Alto): F# -> C#

Why these may be musical anyway:

- In fugue texture, passing, neighbor, or sequence-driven lines may defer or avoid immediate tendency-tone resolution.
- Inner voices can sometimes move to chordal tones other than tonic if harmony is clear and voice leading remains smooth.

Correction options:

- Preferred: move F# to G in the next note in the same voice, especially at cadences and downbeats.
- If harmonic function requires otherwise, delay but eventually complete the tendency resolution by step.
- Revoice surrounding parts so F# becomes non-structural (passing tone) with weaker accent.

2) Voice Crossing (20)

Why this rule is flagged:

- A lower voice moves above a higher voice (or vice versa), blurring registral hierarchy.
- The revised detector already ignores unison landings and direct pitch swaps, so these are more likely true crossings.

Representative report examples:

- m.9 beat 1.00: Soprano crosses Alto; Alto crosses Tenor
- m.16 beat 2.00: Alto crosses Tenor
- m.38 beat 1.00: Alto crosses Tenor

Why these may be musical anyway:

- Imitative writing can tolerate brief crossings when subjects overlap.
- Some crossings are texturally intentional for color or registral exchange.

Correction options:

- Keep each line within its normal register envelope (S > A > T > B).
- When two voices converge, route one by contrary step while the other holds or moves less.
- Re-octavate one note in the inner voice to restore vertical order without changing harmony.

3) Parallel Unisons (107)

Why this rule is flagged:

- Two voices move together in repeated unisons over successive attacks (unison -> unison).
- This merges lines and reduces contrapuntal independence.

Representative report examples:

- m.6 beat 2.00: Soprano & Tenor unison -> unison
- Many sustained chains in Bass & Viola through middle sections

Why these may be musical anyway:

- If one line is a reinforcement doubling (especially in arrangements), repeated unisons can be deliberate.
- With Viola removed, many of these may disappear in the practical version.

Correction options:

- Convert one member of the pair to thirds, sixths, or oblique motion.
- Keep occasional unison arrivals but avoid repeated consecutive unison motion.
- Offset one voice rhythmically by suspending or anticipating its next pitch.

4) Parallel Octaves (13)

Why this rule is flagged:

- Two voices form a perfect octave on one attack and another perfect octave on the next while moving in similar motion.
- This weakens perceived independence similarly to parallel unisons.

Representative report examples:

- m.7 beat 3.00: Soprano & Bass (and Soprano & Viola)
- m.21 beat 1.00: Alto & Bass (and Alto & Viola)

Why these may be musical anyway:

- In thicker ensemble textures, occasional octave reinforcement can be stylistically tolerated.
- But repeated structural octaves are generally treated as an error in strict species-style counterpoint.

Correction options:

- Alter one voice by step to arrive at 10th/6th instead of 8ve.
- Use contrary motion into the second sonority.
- Reassign one voice note to neighboring chord tone.

5) Parallel Perfect Fifths (17)

Why this rule is flagged:

- Consecutive perfect fifths in similar motion between two parts.
- In strict common-practice pedagogy, this is one of the primary independence violations.

Representative report examples:

- m.11 beat 3.00: Soprano & Tenor
- m.21 beat 2.00: Soprano & Bass (and with Viola)
- m.32 beat 2.00: Alto & Bass

Why these may be musical anyway:

- In sequential passages, temporary fifth chains may arise from pattern transposition.
- Still usually worth reducing if you want stricter pedagogical compliance.

Correction options:

- Change one target note by step to produce a 6th/3rd at the second sonority.
- Introduce contrary or oblique motion in one voice between the two chords.
- Break sequence literalism for one event to avoid the repeated perfect interval.

6) Large Leap (11)

Why this rule is flagged:

- Melodic leaps of 10+ semitones (minor seventh or larger), including octave-plus motions.
- Large skips are harder to sing and often demand compensating stepwise recovery.

Representative report examples:

- m.30 beat 1.00 (Alto): leap of 14 semitones
- m.32 beat 1.00 (Bass): leap of 14 semitones

Why these may be musical anyway:

- Instrumental fugues can support larger leaps than vocal writing.
- Octave transfers can be expressive if balanced by contour and phrase design.

Correction options:

- Replace large leap with two smaller intervals via passing notes.
 - If keeping the leap, follow with stepwise motion opposite the leap direction.
 - Redistribute octave transfer to another voice where tessitura is more natural.
- 7) Melodic Tritone (2)

Why this rule is flagged:

- A single voice leaps by tritone (augmented 4th/diminished 5th), often considered harsh in strict melodic writing.

Representative report examples:

- m.16 beat 1.50: Bass (and Viola in full-score analysis) C# -> G

Why these may be musical anyway:

- In harmonic minor/sequence contexts, tritone outlines can occur idiomatically in instrumental lines.

Correction options:

- Fill the span with passing motion instead of direct leap.
- Redirect one endpoint to nearest chord tone producing a perfect 4th/5th or major/minor 3rd.
- Keep harmonic target but adjust rhythm to approach/leave by step.

8) Direct (Hidden) Fifths (2)

Why this rule is flagged:

- Outer voices move in similar motion into a perfect fifth, with upper voice leaping.
- This can mimic the effect of parallels even without literal consecutive perfect intervals.

Representative report examples:

- m.16 beat 2.00: Alto & Bass (outer-voice interpretation in current indexing)
- m.32 beat 1.50: Alto & Bass

Why these may be musical anyway:

- In fast contrapuntal textures, some hidden perfects are acceptable if weakly accented and linearly justified.

Correction options:

- Change upper voice approach to stepwise motion.
- Approach target by contrary motion in one outer voice.
- Shift one note to a non-perfect interval at arrival.

Recommended workflow to fix efficiently

1. Prioritize structural errors first: Parallel P5ths, Parallel Octaves, Direct 5ths.

2. Next clean tendency-tone handling at cadences: Leading tone unresolved.

3. Then smooth local line shape: Large leaps and Melodic tritones.

4. Treat Parallel unisons and Voice crossings with musical discretion in imitative passages.

5-minute triage pass:

- Focus measures: 7, 9, 16, 21, 32.
- In each, first remove repeated perfect intervals in outer parts.
- Then ensure any accented F# resolves to G unless intentionally sequenced.

End of review.